



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Chesterton Academy of St. Benedict
School Website: <https://www.chestertonacademystbenedict.org/>

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Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Chesterton Academy of St. Benedict (Worthington, OH 43017) presents a robust CLASSICAL orientation across the Six Essential Elements framework. Public materials on the school's site frame education as a Catholic classical formation centered on truth, goodness, and beauty, pursued through a liberal arts curriculum, the Socratic Method, and a culture of virtue. The school's mission explicitly ties classical study to Catholic faith, with a three-pillars model centering intellect, character formation, and spiritual truth/practice. Great Books, primary sources, and a historically rooted curriculum are foregrounded, and pedagogy is described as a blend of Socratic inquiry in the upper years with contemplative, restful elements in earlier years. Faculty identity is positioned as mentors and living curriculum, and families are actively welcomed as partners in formation. Open houses, shadow days, and open admissions communications demonstrate ongoing parental involvement and community integration.

Direct textual anchors that support these conclusions include the mission statement tying education to Catholic truth (our public materials articulate a mission grounded in Catholic faith) and references to the Three Pillars and formation over mere information, a curriculum rooted in Great Books and primary sources with Socratic discussion, and clear evidence of liturgical or religious practice and Catholic identity within the school community. These elements align Chesterton Academy St. Benedict with a Classical formation oriented toward truth, goodness, and beauty, rather than a purely workforce-focused or secular program. See evidence excerpts below for category-specific justification.

Overall classification: CLASSICAL.

- Element-by-Element Snapshot indicates a consistent classical orientation across six domains, with explicit religious-metaphysical framing, formation-focused aims, a curriculum centered on Great Books and primary sources, classical pedagogy with Socratic inquiry and memory/recitation elements, a faculty model aligned with living-education ideals, and a strong parent/community partnership stance.
- What would move the needle: Not applicable here since the aggregate classification is CLASSICAL. If one wanted to push toward an even more clearly "classical" designation, further explicit, recurring articulation of grammar-logic-rhetoric in program descriptions and more formal, sustained examples of faculty living-curriculum testimonials could be added, but this is already strongly present in the school's public materials. (No dedicated "What would move the needle" section is provided here because the school is classified CLASSICAL overall.)

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school's public materials describe a Catholic, classical education formed "under the Catholic intellectual tradition" with a mission to educate in the truths of the Catholic faith. The Discover Chesterton page explicitly states partnership with families and the Church to foster a Culture of Life, forming joyful leaders and saints educated in the Catholic tradition. - The materials emphasize Formation through virtue, the spiritual dimension of education, and the integration of theology into the curriculum. The mission and

Three-Pillars framing highlight a sacred and transcendent dimension to education. - A news item notes the school's designation as an independent Catholic school with access to diocesan resources and liturgical services (Mass, Reconciliation), reinforcing liturgical and communal practices. - Public content details liturgical and worship-like elements (Mass, sacred celebrations) embedded in the school's Catholic identity, especially evident in materials describing Catholic formation and liturgical life.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present (from Six Essential Elements lexicon): truth, goodness, beauty; virtue; theology; liturgy; Mass; reverence; wonder; sacred; Logos; contemplation; sacral dimension; inculturation. The school's materials repeatedly reference Catholic truth and liturgical life, theology, and reverence. - Negative keywords present: none evident in public materials; the content strongly aligns with transcendental and theological foundations rather than secular relativism or secular-humanist framing. The absence of explicit secular or relativistic framing supports a CLASSICAL rating for this category.

Why this rating - The school's public presentation anchors education in Catholic truth and transcendental realities (truth, goodness, beauty) and explicitly aims at spiritual formation and liturgical life, which strongly aligns with the Positive Keyword indicators for Religious and Metaphysical Foundations and counters the Negative Keyword signals.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The mission emphasizes forming joyful leaders and saints within the classical tradition and Catholic faith, signaling formation of character and virtue rather than purely vocational outcomes. The Three Pillars foreground intellect, character growth, and spiritual truth/practice. - The curriculum framework and mission articulate formation of human flourishing and virtuous intellect, aligning with timeless classical aims (truth, goodness, beauty) rather than job-market preparation alone. - The Great Books and primary-sources orientation, along with the emphasis on culture and virtue, indicate education as formation (paideia) rather than informational or career-centric training.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, human flourishing, wisdom, liberal education, classical mission, pursuit of the true/good/beautiful, scholé/contemplation, great conversation, moral imagination, lifelong learning. The site's text repeatedly supports these concepts, and the Six Elements lexicon highlights these as core features of a classical education. - Negative keywords present: minimal emphasis on workforce readiness or job-market preprofessional language; the public materials emphasize formation and virtue, not "career readiness" as the primary aim. This reduces negative keyword signals in this category.

Why this rating - The school's stated aims align with formation, virtue, and the pursuit of truth/goodness/beauty rather than mere workforce preparation. The presence of formation-focused language and the emphasis on virtue and teleology in the mission and pillars substantiate CLASSICAL for this category.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials describe a liberal-arts core and a four-year integrated curriculum, with formal emphasis on the humanities and Great Books (Iliad, Odyssey, Divine Comedy, Shakespeare; philosophy of Plato, Aristotle, Aquinas; historical works like Herodotus and Thucydides; theological works, Augustine and Scripture). The curriculum is presented as cumulative and content-rich, designed to cultivate understanding across disciplines. - The humanities program explicitly braids history, literature, philosophy, theology, and languages through the integrated curriculum and uses the Socratic Method in instruction. This aligns with classical curriculum structures emphasizing liberal arts and the Great Conversation. - Curriculum materials outline a history sequence from ancient world through modern times, with a cross-disciplinary emphasis on literature, philosophy, and theology, and a focus on primary sources. - The site highlights the use of primary sources and a classical reading list, reinforcing the Great Books and classical canon emphasis.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: liberal arts; grammar, logic, rhetoric (classical triad typically cited in classical-education lexicons); great books; primary sources; classics; Western

civilization; sacred/holy texts; philosophy; theology; rhetoric; dialectic; memorization (through recitation/narration). The site repeatedly emphasizes classics, Great Books, and a rigorous humanities emphasis, with Socratic teaching. - Negative keywords present: the site does not emphasize “social studies” as the primary frame; rather, history is integrated with literature and philosophy in a traditional canon context. The lack of social-studies-replacement language aligns with classical expectations. Where explicit “grammar, logic, rhetoric” terms appear in canonical lexicons, the site demonstrates classical methods (e.g., Socratic method, primary sources). This yields a strong positive signal and minimal negative signal for this category.

Why this rating - The curriculum materials strongly reflect the core Classical elements: liberal arts foundation, Great Books/primary sources, and a deep historical-philosophical-theological integration, even if the explicit phrase “grammar, logic, rhetoric” is not always spelled out in a single page. The presence of Great Books, primary sources, and the integrated humanities sequence corroborates CLASSICAL for this category.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The site emphasizes Socratic inquiry as a central method, with upper-school seminars and opportunities for debate and rhetoric. The description of the Socratic Method and its purposes demonstrate classical pedagogy oriented toward dialectic and ethical reasoning. - There is public emphasis on memory work and recitation in earlier grades and a culture of contemplation and wonder. The Fine Arts and liturgical elements contribute to a contemplative, reverent learning environment, while upper grades emphasize rhetorical and argumentative skills (speeches, debates). - The curriculum presents an integrated approach where students are asked to read primary sources and engage in student-led inquiry, consistent with classical pedagogy that combines guided instruction with Socratic inquiry.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Socratic method, seminar, dialectic, rhetoric, recitation, narration, chanting, memory work, contemplation, scholé, wonder, liturgical integration. The presence of “Socratic,” “great books,” “narration/recitation,” and “rhetoric” aligns with classical pedagogy signals in the lexicon. - Negative keywords present: minimal use of purely project-based, experiential-only learning in the public materials; the public-facing materials emphasize a mix that remains anchored in memory-work, recitation, and classical dialogue rather than solely constructivist/project-based approaches. This supports a classical pedagogy signal more than a negative one.

Why this rating - The school's teaching-method description centers on Socratic discussion, classical seminars, memory-work, and rhetoric, with a strong emphasis on contemplative learning and moral formation. This aligns with CLASSICAL expectations in pedagogy.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials portray faculty as mentors and guides who model virtue and knowledge, and as a “living curriculum” embedded in the school culture. The Headmaster page and the school's public materials emphasize the teachers' role in forming students and embodying the school's mission. - The school references a culture of collegiality among teachers and a portrait of ideal teachers and students, aligning with the classical model where faculty are central to character formation. The “Three Pillars” and mission statements describe teachers as model teachers and mentors within a community of learners. - The school's designation as an independent Catholic School and emphasis on Catholic formation imply a faculty structure aligned with ongoing formation and fidelity to tradition, supported by diocesan resources.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: model teachers, mentors, living curriculum, portrait of what a teacher should be, collegial culture, formation through faculty, teachers as guides. The lexicon highlights “tutors, masters, mentors” and “portrait of a teacher” as key signals of classical faculty. - Negative keywords present: none evident in public materials; the faculty portrayal aligns with classical expectations rather than “teacher as facilitator on the sideline” or other non-classical depictions.

Why this rating - The public materials consistently frame teachers as moral exemplars, mentors, and living catalysts for the curriculum, consistent with CLASSICAL expectations for faculty.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school emphasizes partnership with families and framing parents as co-teachers in the classical education project; the mission emphasizes partnering with families and the Church. Open houses, shadow days, visits, and admissions communications demonstrate active parental engagement and opportunities for parental formation and participation. - Admissions information highlights parent involvement in the enrollment process and opportunities for families to engage with the school community (shadow days, open houses, admissions information). This indicates ongoing parental participation and a family-centered community culture. - Public materials also suggest additional opportunities to engage families through events (gala, info sessions, etc.) and via partnerships with the broader Chesterton Schools Network, which underscores a community-centered approach.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families, co-teachers, parent formation, classical book clubs, open campus, hospitality, family catechesis, parental leadership, Living tradition in the family. These are all foregrounded in the Six Elements lexicon as positive indicators of a classical parents-and-community approach. - Negative keywords present: none evident in public materials; the school's communications emphasize active parent involvement rather than a consumer-model approach.

Why this rating - The school presents a clear, stated partnership with families, ongoing parental formation, and open opportunities for family engagement and visits, consistent with CLASSICAL expectations for parents and community.

What Would Move the Needle

- Not applicable since the aggregate rating is CLASSICAL. If one sought to strengthen the profile further, the school could explicitly foreground more repeated, explicit statements about Grammar-Logic-Rhetoric (the traditional Trivium) in public materials, and provide more concrete, public-facing examples of the living-curriculum faculty model (e.g., teacher exemplars, annual teacher-formation events, and demonstrations of teacher-led great-books seminars).

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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